DURABLE DATA AND GOVERNANCE BOUNDARIES

Policies that depend on data are only as stable as the data they reference. At ACME, replacing department names with durable roles made policies more resilient—but it also shifted responsibility. Roles are governed assets: who defines them, who maintains them, and how they relate to real-world responsibilities are all questions of policy governance. Governance ensures that the data on which policies rely is trustworthy. We'll revisit this topic in chapter 14, where governance defines how attributes like role, team, and project membership are validated and kept fresh.

Here are two additional examples of brittle versus improved designs that demonstrate the same principle:

Example 1: Project codes vs. project entities

A developer writing an early access rule for project documents might be tempted to key it on a project code:

```
when { resource.project_code == "ALPHA" };
```

Hardcoding the project code ties access to a value that might change when projects are renamed or merged. A better approach references the durable project entity itself:

```
when { resource in Project::"alpha".documents };
```

This maintains the policy's validity even if the project's label changes because the underlying entity stays the same.

Example 2: Manager names vs. relationship data

Another common mistake is linking permissions to a specific person's name:

```
when { principal.manager == "carol" };
```